relatives by ties of blood, marriage or adoption file an FIR, even police officers can take suo motu cognisance of conversions. Not only would a marriage solemnised with the 'sole purpose' of conversion be null and void, any child born out of such a marriage would belong to the mother's original religion.

ADVANCE WARNING

The law also mandates one of the strictest notice requirements in the country. Anyone wishing to convert must give 60 days' prior notice as also a post-conversion declaration within 21 days to the district magistrate, who in turn shall notify it and call for suggestions and objections. The latter can bring on a police inquiry. Any violations would be non-bailable, attracting punishments of up to 10 years in jail and Rs 7 lakh fine.

The bill produced interesting political reactions. The Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) broke ranks with its Opposition partners in the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) to back it—choosing to burnish its Hindutva credentials openly after a phase of drift that saw minority voters close ranks with it. The NCP backed the bill as part of the ruling Mahayuti, but its leaders were guarded. "Any conversion on grounds of conviction cannot be opposed," said Idris Naikwadi, NCP MLC. Fellow party MLC Amol Mitkari, too, warned about possible misuse.

Fadnavis said the law—drawing on state laws enacted since 1968—was not "targeted at any religion". What he cast as a protective armature, activists call a virtual state veto on inter-faith marriages as well as a Damocles' sword dangled on Muslims using the 'love jihad' bogey—Abu Azmi of the Samajwadi Party says its only purpose would be "to trouble and oppress the minorities".

Civil society groups see in the law an intrusive regulation of personal choices. Shamsuddin Tamboli of the Muslim Satyashodhak Mandal notes its friction with a variety of constitutional guarantees, and warns that it would enable vigilantism. Noorjehan Safia Niaz, co-founder, Bharatiya Muslim Mahila Andolan, calls it a "problematic" trespass onto personal spaces.

Advocate Lara Jesani, national secretary, People's Union for Civil Liberties, warns that its target base goes beyond Muslims. "The law will target the right to choice of women and the right of the young to choose their partners," she says, adding that Dalits, tribals and minorities would be targeted by the Hindu right-wing. The government, she said, had failed to present data on conversions to show such "draconian provisions" were even needed. ■

Takeaways

- Maharashtra bill puts a higher bar on change of faith. Critics call it a virtual veto on interfaith marriages, a tool for vigilantism
- The definition of 'allurement' is widened, cops allowed to move suo motu, and a stringent advance notice clause red flags
- Shiv Sena (UBT) breaks with Oppn to back Fadnavis regime on bill



▶ UTTAR PRADESH

Age of Kanshi

As Congress and SP back a Bharat Ratna for the iconic BSP founder, UP's drifting Dalit vote is in focus for 2027

By **Avaneesh Mishra**

IN UTTAR PRADESH, KANSHI RAM SEEMS to have of late become an object of reverence across parties. One of the most influential architects of Dalit mobilisation in North India, the strategic energies of his remarkable life in politics were entirely in the service of the formation he created from scratch, the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP). His legacy, after he passed on in 2006, was deemed its exclusive property. But that looks set to change.

As the state edges towards the 2027 assembly election, everyone wants a piece of the Kanshi legacy that once had a single, undisputed claimant in BSP chief Mayawati. Across the spectrum, parties are reaching back to invoke his ideas, his struggles and his symbolism, each trying to position itself as equal inheritors.

A UNIVERSAL ICON

The latest round of invocations began in March, when Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi said in Lucknow that, had Jawaharlal Nehru been alive, he would have chosen Kanshi Ram as chief minister of UP. Addressing a 'samvidhan sammelan', Rahul described Kanshi as a leader who transformed how marginalised communities engaged with politics. He acknowledged the Congress's own failures had created the need for a leader like Kanshi.

Drawing a line from Kanshi to B.R. Ambedkar, he echoed the essential ideas put out by the icons to reiterate the Congress's demand for a nationwide caste cen-